

12. Afterword: Code switching: Feeling the ‘emotional turn’ in digital cultural heritage

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Abstract

Sustaining the ‘reflexive outlook’ called for at the outset of the volume, this final chapter pauses to notice what it calls an ‘emotional turn’ in digital cultural heritage – namely, a growing emphasis on the affective dimension of using digital technology in the everyday work of the culture sector. The discussion places this intellectual and professional re-routing into a wider academic context. It makes the case that, far from novel and sudden, this new sensibility to emotion within cultural technology, follows (and, in fact, builds upon) a number of person-centred processes and principles pre-figured in professional practice and thinking.

Keywords: emotionality, affective, theory, framework, practice, scholarship.

Introduction

From a horizon of perspectives and through an array of rich accounts, this volume helps us to appraise the evolving role that digital technology plays within the socially purposeful work of European cultural heritage organisations. Part compendium of case studies, and part gazetteer of impactful practice, the chapters here combine to evidence the opportunity (indeed, the responsibility) the culture sector has today in building provision in participatory and inclusive ways – aspirationally and ethically for everyone, everywhere. Here this mix of institutions and professionals cohere to form a tableau of reflective work and critical thinking – an image of what probably surrounds us *now*, of what is plausibly coning *next*, as well as what possibly might need to be *new*.

Strikingly, through these chapters, we notice the concepts of ‘cultural heritage’, ‘digital technologies’ and ‘social innovation’ plotted in different ways – concurrently, but without contradiction. A complexity that speaks to the multi-dimensional way in which any discussion of cultural technology must always operate. We see, for instance, digital technology in one role as a catalyst – helping cultural organisations to confront whether they have societal relevance as an institution. (In those instances, digital provides the challenge of whether these organisations are apt and fit for purpose, questioning why they might need to adapt, and modelling what they might need to become – adapting from keepers to storytellers, from collectors to editors, and from initiators to partners, if not followers.) At the same time, we also see digital technology in the form of a tool – helping cultural organisations to act in relevant ways. (In those instances, digital technologies are not the provocation but rather the appropriate

channels and platforms, signs, and behaviours, by which a cultural organisation might seek to be more relevant to the rhythms and codes of its contemporary society.) And yet, further still we see digital technology operating as context – part of the cultural landscape and ways of thinking within which relevancy is constructed and framed. (In those instances, digital becomes the circumstance in which, and the criteria by which, ‘relevance’ is determined by the cultural organisation and its publics.) The discussions collected here allow us to identify these axes and layers of cultural technology. With cultural organisations attempting to: appraise their *relevance* as institutions in a digital age; communicate in a *relevant* way for a digital age; and define *relevancy*, culturally and societally, within a digital age. Digital technology – all at once – as disrupter, as enabler, as well as subject.

However, as we note (and enjoy) this multi-dimensionality of cultural technology, we might also pause to notice another characteristic to the studies compiled here. For, weaving across the summaries and syntheses of the volume runs another theme – distinctive, sustained, and unavoidable. A theme that demonstrates both a distinctive maturity in professional practice, as well as a prevailing priority in cultural discourse. That theme is ‘emotion’. We notice it, for instance, in the way these accounts of progressive inclusive digital cultural heritage practice are at pains to embrace the diversity of interests and cultural perspectives of stakeholders – recognising different contexts, reconciling different perspectives, responding to different needs. It is seen in the shape of the creative approaches to inclusive digital storytelling, in the programming for locally-focused placemaking, and in the creative outlooks and educational priorities of particular users within specific locations and situations – be that a classroom, a stage, a screening, or a city tour.

Similarly, we also notice it in the way these projects and programmes have ensured agency within their partners, abdicated responsibility to their co-producers, and moved aside to assign leadership to the users and communities themselves. It is heard there in the beats of ‘bringing in’, ‘stepping back’, ‘lifting up’ – the co-creative activities, the approaches that privilege marginalised voices and narratives, the processes ready to apply a ‘post-custodial’ mindset to cultural heritage. Likewise, we notice it in the way these institutions and consortia have acknowledged the judgments and biases that remain inherent in professional practice, and systemic within organisational process and culture. In this case, it is felt in those acts of enablement and empowerment (developing community-driven tools and inventive platforms constructed with social innovation in mind), and it is felt in those acts of exposure and reckoning (confronting prejudicing legacies within data models, coding, and systems). In each of these cases (whether the empathetic design, leaderful trust, or cultural respect), the language and priority of digital cultural heritage is distinctive. Rather than focusing only on operational efficiency or machine compatibility, instead it is also the personal and human dimension to using, managing, creating, and understanding digital in/with/for/by cultural heritage institutions that comes vividly into view. More precisely put, it is the *emotionality* of cultural technology that starts to matter as much – if not, at times, more.

It is this shift in focus, energy and expectation that deserves our attention. This after all, is a re-centring from ‘technology’ to ‘people’. A change in emphasis – in professional practice and in academic discourse – from (only) business processes and technical systems, to (also) the feeling and experience of digital work and the digital workplace of the museum. What we are witnessing (in this volume, and in our practice and scholarship more widely) is a growing emphasis on the affective dimension of using digital technology in the everyday work of the culture sector; a switch to emotionality.

Sensing the postdigital

To help us feel for the finer contours of this emotionality, there is value first acknowledging the broader intellectual and professional context into which this discussion on disciplinary and operational sits. This, after all, is a moment in the academy and the culture sector in which digital technology is managed, articulated and conceptualised within some noticeable and distinct frames, namely: *digital maturity*, *mediatisation* and the *metamodern*.

It has, for instance, become increasingly routine for cultural heritage organisations to deploy the nomenclature and the day-to-day business processes of digital management. Evermore, as cultural organisations continue to adopt digital technology and adapt to an increasingly digital society around them, the normative expectation within these organisational settings is for strategies, policies, systems and tools to be in-place that embed digital thinking and digital working. Today, the starting point for digital leadership (inside the organisation) and digital scholarship (of, with and by the organisation) is to assume the presence of technology. To be a cultural organisation today, is to be inherently information-rich, data-driven, multi-channel, interaction-ready – with digital technology more commonly innate within the organisation’s vision of itself, informing its business processes, characterising its workplace culture, and shaping the skills development of its staff. This, in business terms, is the culture sector’s ‘digital maturity’.

Alongside this maturing of business confidence, there has been a similar development in the language and framing of the distinct role of the cultural organisations within digital society. Many cultural organisations today find themselves within parts of society that are increasingly defined in media terms. Digitally speaking, the world in which these organisations sit, which they reflect, and which comes to them, is one that is expansively dataful, progressively connected and relentlessly inventive. This is a society which not only proliferates its use of media technology, but escalates the ways it understands itself, its relationship with others, its sense of space and time, in media terms. And yet, as well as being confronted with a mediatised world, cultural organisations are uniquely mediatised spaces. They are media-rich landscapes, assembled in a choreography of interfaces and sensory channels, unlike most other (if not any other) public spaces.

As well as these business and academic points of maturity and development, sits another, more profound, philosophical shift. At the same time as cultural organisations have adopted and adapted to digital technology, and alongside the new insights and lexicons that media studies has brought to cultural heritage studies, another (third) context demands to be noticed. Today, the thinking on which discussions around digital cultural heritage is predicated, the vocabulary through which it is articulated, and the logic through which it is reasoned, is affected by wider and deeper shifts in our cultural condition(s). Plainly put, whereas at its point of adoption cultural heritage technology was part of a distinctly twentieth-century drive to use the power of the computer to systematise organisational practice and provision, the software and hardware of digital technology today have gone on to assume a more complex role within professional practice and academic scholarship. Similarly, whereas at the turn of the last century cultural heritage technology was experiencing a period of interrogation (both professional scepticism and academic critique), the discourse of cultural technology today has developed nuanced and layered forms of engagement. Across these decades of change, the shift can be read as from a modernist building project to a post-modernist questioning forum, to today a contemporary philosophical condition that is comfortable reconciling the two. To be a cultural heritage organisation today is to both embrace the mobilising potential of technology as an agent of positive systemic change, whilst also being able to challenge, expose and (if necessary, at times, decline) that same set of technologies. This, in conceptual terms, is the culture sector's new-found place within the 'meta-modern'.

And so, our discussion here of a 'turn to emotionality' within museum technology practice and scholarship, is helped by (and perhaps even best understood within) these wider business, academic and philosophical contexts. It is these concepts of 'digital maturity', 'mediatisation' and 'meta-modernity', which together offer the co-ordinates within which we can notice and express the post-digital condition of the culture sector.

Nurturing the Affective and Emotional Turn

Cultural technology's shift to 'emotion' marks a poignant stage in its maturity – adding a vital (if not overlooked) human dimension to decades of technological and business development. After all, looking back on recent history of the adoption of (and adaption to) digital technology we see institutions that, understandably perhaps, were initially focused on making the systems and tools work effectively. This was the era of experimentation, of constructing the first data models and networks, and of charting and following where users (and the market) might take the new computing. After several decades of grappling with hardware and software, putting in place the systems and standards for interoperability, and assembling the case for the 'new technology' in the culture sector, emphasis turned to businesses processes – and operationalising technology, steady-state, day-to-day into the working life of cultural organisations. This was the era of strategizing with digital, of developing the first policies

around data use, social media and digital collecting, and of embracing the role that digital might play in the visioning of the culture sector.

The change we see today, however, is a further turn – and one towards the element that was perhaps always present in this story of development, but that never held the centre ground. It is the element which these initial experiments and adoptions with computers required, and on which the subsequent strategizing and operationalising was based, but was never brought to the fore. That final element, alongside ‘platforms’ and ‘processes’ on which all digital transformation relies, is, of course, ‘people’. Through their long history of technological adoption, cultural organisations always knew that the technology was there to serve users and community. They always knew that new business processes were in place to ensure effective mobilisation of their staff and delivery of its provision. But what professional practice (and academic discourse) did not do perhaps as much as it ought, was look to the experience of its leaders, its workers, and its change makers, of initiating this adoption of technology. This is our moment of affective and emotional turn.

Sensitised by the turn to emotion more generally within digital cultural heritage studies, but also profoundly affected (undoubtedly) by the experiences of a global pandemic and its impact on the emotional intelligence and literacy of the culture sector, our subject is now ready, to confront and consider the human experience of adopting digital. Now that the digital systems work, that the tools are reliable, and now that the strategies are mature and policies in place, we are ready to look at ourselves and reflect – with care and insight – on the emotionality of digital transformation. We are ready to reflect upon how crucial people (workers) are to making a cultural organisation digital, but also what the emotional consequences are of taking a cultural organisation through a moment of digital change. It is time, in short, from this new perspective, to ask a new set of questions around the affective dimension of cultural heritage sector work with digital technology.

Feeling emotion in cultural technology

Excitingly, the concepts, vocabulary, and reasoning, as well as the practical tools, for understanding the emotional dimension of digital change are (as this volume attests) emerging from an array of contemporary projects. These are helping the sector and the academy to find where to start, how to talk and in which direction to head when thinking through emotionality in a digital context, but also (more practically) how to lead and be part of digital change in the museum with empathy and emotional intelligence.

First, this emotional turn is helping us to see digital change as *contextual* and site-specific – rather than generic across the sector. Starting to take the perspective of individual cultural sector workers helps us to appreciate how much ‘place’ and ‘situation’ impacts upon why and how digital change happens in an organisation. After all, cultural organisations are diverse in size, governance, funding, and subject focus. They are on different parts of their journey to

digital maturation. Their ambitions and strategies (in who they serve, why and how) are unique to their circumstance, capacity, capability, and resource. Considered in this way, a person-centred and context-based approach to digital change in the culture sector, becomes self-evident.

Second, the emotional turn is enabling us to think *holistically* about digital change – rather than just in technological or business terms. Beginning our thought process with people (rather than machines) helps us critically to notice the cultural, psychological, and personal characteristics of digital change in an organisation. Digital transformation relies upon vision, strategy, processes and systems to justify, initiate, support and enable its activity and purpose. However, it is leaders (and the behaviours they model, and the empathy they show), as well as individual museum workers (and the culture of work they build between them, and the agency and resilience they possess) that ultimately will drive any such digital activity and change.

Third, the emotional turn in digital cultural heritage is enabling us to think *purposefully* about digital change – rather than just in technocratic or deterministic terms. When the thought process on why to use digital technology begins from the assumption that it must always be to serve the social good to which the cultural organisation aspires, this immediately brings into focus a number of questions and priorities around equity, inclusion, diversity and access. Looking at people (and not just the technology), listening to lived experience of working with digital in cultural organisations (and not just the business processes), reveals another set of fundamental themes and challenges for both the profession and the academy. This perspective will help us to confront a number of germane questions, not least: the extent to which our digital workplaces are accessible to all that work there. What cultural assumptions (and prejudices) are embedded within working practices and processes? Who has agency and who leads (and who does not) in the culture sector's digital landscape? And what within the institutional delivery of digital transformation is not understood, not recognised, and (even) not seen?

Conclusion: 'Code switching'

The double meaning of our title here denotes not just the literal change ('switching') towards digital technology ('code') we are witnessing in cultural organisations today, but then also the new emotional skills of empathy we will need to deliver this change effectively. This is not intended as a glib metaphor, but rather a careful acknowledgment of the business maturity, emotional intelligence, as well as layered and concurrent meta-modern thinking, that is beginning to characterise this emerging next generation of cultural technology practice and scholarship. In sociolinguistics, the idea of 'code-switching' relates to 'the alternating use of two or more 'codes' within one conversational episode' (Auer 1998, p. 17), an 'alternation between the different varieties which people speak' (Gardner-Chloros 2009, p. 11). As such, whether moving between languages, dialects or the idioms of different communities, 'code-switching' (as an area of study, but also as a linguistic act) is inextricably linked to questions

of power, inequality, and rights (Auer 1998, p. 20). Deploying the term in our discussion here, therefore, signals an intentionality to notice how more than one discourse can exist (concurrently) within our practice and discourse of museum technology, but also how the movement between these discourses (between the technological, the managerial, and the emotional) is itself a meaningful act worthy of attention.

Perhaps more profound still, we note that when psycholinguistic studies first used the term ‘code-switching’, the word ‘code’ was originally appropriated from the practices and disciplines of communication technology, and the term ‘switching’ was literally understood as ‘something similar to flicking an electric switch’ (Gardner-Chloros, 2009, p. 11). And so, to use the term as we are here, back in a computing and technological context, is itself cyclical, if not (pleasingly) autological. Moreover, our continued ‘code switching’ in cultural technology (reflecting on the emotionality of use technology, and the role of technology in shaping our emotional self), will remind us of the deep links that remain between technology and people – each always and inescapably shaped by the other.

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